PROMETHEUS PARADOX

A story about virtue
By Percy Pham

INT. BRICK APARTMENT - 4TH FLOOR - NIGHT
A police car drove onto the street. Siren screamed in the silent night.

KYRON stitched the wounds
You really got your work cut out for those guys.

ARCHIE chuckled
The police… down there? Or the paramedics.

KYRON sighed
Based on the people you beat to pulp… Flip a coin

ARCHIE
Those are criminals

KYRON
Then what makes you different

ARCHIE
I didn't do what they did

KYRON didn't say anything and cut the string. He moved on to another wound without revealing any visible feelings.

ARCHIE (CONT'D)
I mean it… I track them down and punish them for something they did. They made their choice first.

KYRON
And you did the same thing.

ARCHIE
I have no other choice.

KYRON
You know… a year ago, when we first met after you saved me in that alley.

He pulled the black thread tight and snipped it with the scissors.

[CUT TO:]

EXT. DARK ALLEY - RAINY NIGHT
A ROBBER held a gun, struck KYRON across the head, and knocked him down. He began digging through KYRON's trench coat for a wallet.

Lightning struck.

A silhouette stood at the alley entrance, footsteps masked by the rumbling thunder and raindrops. ARCHIE charged. He grabbed the robber by the neck and slammed his skull into the dumpster.

ARCHIE gave him no room to breathe. With a driving kick, he sent the ROBBER crashing into the dumpster again, gripped the robber's gun hand, and snapped the elbow. The gun clattered against wet pavement.

BANG!

The gunshot blended seamlessly into the thunder.

ARCHIE drove blow after blow into the man's face. Desperate, the ROBBER gestured frantically to yield, but Archie drew his blade and pinned the outstretched hand straight to the rusted metal

[CUT TO: BEHIND KYRON]

KYRON watched in horror, trapped by the violence blocking his escape. ARCHIE continued to rain strikes into the robber's face.

ARCHIE
Why did you do it?

The ROBBER was too dazed to form words. Archie drove his punch into the steel bin, inches next to the ROBBER’s head in anger.

ARCHIE
Why?

Silence. Archie stared deep into the man’s eyes, searching for a reason to justify what the ROBBER did and what he was doing. KYRON watched, the realization dawning on him.

ARCHIE hammered his fist into the trash can, then hurled the robber into the brick wall. ARCHIE's knuckles were torn and swollen.

Scrambling along the wet ground, the robber clawed toward something out of sight. ARCHIE paid him no mind. He turned, reached down, and helped KYRON to his feet.

ARCHIE
Are you okay?

Speechless, KYRON managed only a nod. He looked at ARCHIE's waist.

ARCHIE whispered
You're bleeding.

ARCHIE didn't notice what KYRON was saying and glanced back toward the robber, catching him reaching for a dropped phone.

ARCHIE strode over, picked up the device, and smashed it onto the ground beside the man. He rolled the ROBBER over onto his back. The ROBBER's eyes were in tears, pleading for mercy.

ARCHIE remained cold.

ARCHIE
Are you ready to answer?

Dazed and bleeding, the robber struggled to grasp the situation.

ROBBER
Please… I'm just…

ARCHIE
Just what? Hungry? Scared?… Bored? Addicted?

The ROBBER answered only with a wet cough.

ARCHIE hauled the robber up, pinned him against the wall, and drove a fist into his gut. The robber collapsed, gasping for air. Grabbing the man by the hair, ARCHIE wrenched his head up, looked him in the eye, and snapped a final hook into his jaw, knocking him out cold.

KYRON (CONT'D) (O.V)
I asked why you had to take it so far. Beating them up… terrorized them.

[CUT TO:]

INT. BRICK APARTMENT - 4TH FLOOR - NIGHT
KYRON wiped the blood from the stitches with a clean pad.

KYRON (CONT'D)
When I asked you why you did it, you claimed you were fighting to clean up the street for tomorrow...

[CUT TO:]

EXT. DARK ALLEY - RAINY NIGHT
KYRON ran straight to ARCHIE, pulling the man's hands away to examine the wound. Blood gushed through torn fabric, and KYRON knew instantly it was bad. He scanned the alley for his briefcase, dragged it close, and snapped it open to grab his steel blade and his lighter.

KYRON flicked the lighter to life, holding the steel directly in the flame to heat it red-hot. As the blade was heating up, he glanced to his left and looked at the ROBBER slumped unconscious, leaning against the wall just like ARCHIE.

KYRON (CONT'D) (O.V)
But you're just one of them.

Turning back to ARCHIE's bleeding wound, KYRON pressed the glowing metal straight into the open cut while ARCHIE screamed in pain.

KYRON (CONT'D) (O.V)
Another man burning it all down.

[CUT TO:]

EXT. BRICK APARTMENT - 4TH FLOOR - NIGHT
ARCHIE
We all say that. But when it comes down to dealing with the devil, God personally sent Michael to defeat Lucifer, dragging the devil from heaven into hell, into eternal damnation.

KYRON held out the bottle of painkillers. ARCHIE shook his head and gently pushed the hand away. He then set the bottle down, walked to the kitchen table, and took a sip of water.

KYRON
You are not God. You can’t just play God...

ARCHIE
But I need to do what's right.

KYRON picked up a bottle of water and tossed it to ARCHIE. He caught it, opened the bottle, and took a sip.

KYRON
But how do you know what is right? You don't know anything but your version of what's real and what's not.

ARCHIE
Prometheus stole fire for mankind. It went against Zeus, but he did it anyway because it was the right thing to do. And we all know it.

KYRON chuckled
The same fire that burned the Library of Alexandria to the ground. The same one that gave humans the strength over all other creatures, simply because Prometheus preferred us over his brother's work.

ARCHIE stayed quiet, staring down at the floor in anger before his expression went completely hollow, wearing the look of a man who had lost his faith.

KYRON took his glasses off and rubbed the bridge of his nose
Look... We don't get to just look at someone and decide who they are. Our first lesson is always to learn to be the opposite of who we naturally are. Sure, some change, and some stay the same. Some turn out good, while others stay bad or turn bad.

ARCHIE stood up and put on his black T-shirt.

KYRON (CONT'D)
Isn't that your job? To give them hope? To guide people away from their sins before they fall any deeper, instead of letting your wrath run free?

ARCHIE
You know nothing about my job. Do you know what the worst part is?

KYRON took the black denim hoodie off the chair and threw it at ARCHIE. He caught it and pulled it on.

KYRON looked out the window
What?

ARCHIE
Sitting in that tiny box. Listening to helpless women and children crying for help… Listening to rapists and murderers taunting me while I had to sit there and do nothing. This is not how it should be.

KYRON
Van Gogh died broke. People laughed at him and his work, and didn't realize the beauty of what he was building until long after he was gone. Sometimes a design takes time to take shape and reveal itself.

ARCHIE walked to the window and jumped onto the fire escape. KYRON turned toward the chair where he had just treated ARCHIE, gathering his medical instruments, packing them away, and throwing away the trash.

ARCHIE turned back to KYRON
But at the end of the day… people will always chase their sin. And all they can do is atone for it. That is what we are made for: living with remorse. I don't pretend to know God's plan. But I know that they need to regret what they did. Through guilt… or through fear.